perspective. Photographs and paintings of the town and the life in it, too, have not survived.

Tuticorin harbour, 'formed by a low sandy cape … projecting eastward from the mainland on the south',[15] was 'situated on the north-west shore of the Gulf of Mannar and between the mouths of the Tambrapurni and Veippaur [rivers]'.[16] But the harbour was so shallow that steamers of even moderate draught had to anchor about 10 km from the shore; consequently, passengers had to be conveyed in steam launches. Regular dredging was required to keep the channel open between the shore and the roadstead. A lighthouse on Hare Island guided the crafts and launches used for landing and shipping.

How then did this dump of a port gain prominence—emerging as the second largest port in south India (after Madras) and the sixth largest in India (some even reckoning that it stood fifth[17])—at the time of our study?

The British India Steam Navigation Company

Tuticorin's development was rooted in the rise of Britain as a global empire propelled by its maritime power—'a vital strategic and symbolic resource for Britain's expansive but rapidly integrating trading empire'.[18]

In the early part of the nineteenth century, British merchants and manufacturers were rather unhappy with the low level of Britain's trade with India. Attributing it to the lack of good internal transport, they advocated steam shipping—the was before the advent of railways—to improve this situation. There was an 'undeniable need of the British economy in the 1840s for a speedy development of India as a source of raw materials and a market for finished goods'.[19]

It was during this time that steam took the seas by storm. By the 1830s, steamships had replaced sailing ships globally. The Coromandel Coast caught up a decade later. The great mercantile houses of London exerted pressure on the Empire to introduce steam navigation between India and Britain. British firms in Calcutta, Madras and Bombay strongly backed these efforts. By the 1870s, steam had triumphed in India.[20]